

CDN Incident Alert: 0046. TLP: Clear**Date:****Title**

DE

Coordinated disinformation network uses AI, media impersonation to target German election

20/02/2025

Summary

- In January 2025, there was an uptick of activity by the pro-Kremlin Influence Operation (IO) Operation Overload. A pre-existing coordinated network of 48 accounts on X, focusing on the German election.
- The IO alleged a lack of security around the election, indicating terrorist threats, and aimed to discredit individual MPs and parties.
- The IO videos carry branding from legitimate media organisations, with audio of some genuine reports by these outlets manipulated with the use of AI. The videos also spoof government agencies and academic institutions.
- The IO targets international audiences, posting in five different languages, but not German.
- The reach of the network of 48 accounts has been limited. All engagements with the original videos were from a network of more than 6500 amplifiers. The original videos likely did not gain engagement from genuine X users.
- Ten accounts that posted videos in January have been suspended as of February 12, 2025.
- Further monitoring to detect potential breakout is recommended. Impersonated entities, and relevant institutions should be notified of the operations attempts to mislead international audiences about the German elections. which, in case the content manages to garner organic traction, might undermine their credibility.

Incident

Between January 1 and 31, 2025, a coordinated network of X accounts posted 33 unique videos spreading disinformation about election-related terror and German politicians. The operation targeted politicians include Friedrich Merz, Jeanine Wissler, and Armin Laschet. A bot network consisting of more than 6000 accounts is amplifying this content. Multiple indicators suggest bot-driven amplification, but the clearest evidence is the synchronised engagement pattern. Every post in the dataset received all its reposts within a single minute. For instance, a post on January 27 received all 202 reposts at exactly 6:27 pm CET. Since January 2025, the operation has posed as about 20 organisations, including DW, Sky News, government agencies, and academic institutions. It uses real videos with AI-generated audio to enhance credibility. Thirteen of the 27 videos were posted on January 27 or 28, suggesting that this network might be escalating its campaign in the lead-up to the German election.

Narrative

Meta narrative: Upcoming federal election is not safe due to various terrorist threats

Sub-narratives: Calling out individual politicians for being corrupt and/ or paedophiles, indicating that they cannot be trusted to secure the election process. Allegations that Ukrainian refugees are a threat to German society and that German assistance to Ukraine exposes it to potential Russian military attack.

Impact

Reach: All 10,597 shares of its content came from a coordinated network of amplifier accounts.

Engagement was likely artificially inflated, but confined within its immediate network and its overall impact is therefore limited, the operation's content likely reached some real users on X. The 48 identified accounts collectively garnered 2.5 million views, averaging 52,480 views per post. Despite moderately high view and interactions counts, the campaign failed to achieve further organic spread from X users.

Outcome: None, but may undermine the credibility of politicians if its' content is picked up by real account on X.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: T0079: Divide users by spreading politically contentious disinformation and distract journalists by tagging them directly in posts

- T0100 Co-opt trusted sources: Videos are branded with logos from news outlets, academic institutions, and government agencies
- T0048: Harass: Overload fact-checking organisations and government agencies with tags
- T0044 Seed distortions: Using AI-generated audio to manipulate narration of videos
- T0117: Attract traditional media - via tags/mentions

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Contacted news outlets to pick up the story and expose the IO to a wider audience.
Recommendations: Contact regulator to potentially initiate further action; Contact news outlets and institutions targeted to increase their awareness.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Platforms	(Funder) Logo
Link	Election/ Operation Overload/ Russian FIMI		Institute for Strategic Dialogue	X	